M365-08 · Teams Meetings, Recording & Guest Participation

One stated rule for recording and consent, where recordings and transcripts actually end up, and who is allowed into your meeting.

Field	Value
Document ID	M365-08
Version	1.0 · Known Good edition, by Kevin Zelman
Catalogue domain	A. Microsoft 365
Operating tier	Tier 1 — the front door answers almost everything in this document, and §9 is written to be worked through at Tier 1 without escalating. Tier 3 owns the meeting-policy configuration; Tier 4 owns §2 and §7.
Review cycle	Annually.
What this document does not do	It does not give legal advice, and it does not set HR or training policy. §2 is a recommended organization standard put forward for ratification, not a legal opinion. §7 states the technical rules for session recordings and defers the policy question to senior leadership.

1. Purpose

Teams meetings are the one part of Microsoft 365 that every member of the organization uses, several times a day, without being trained in it. That is fine for most of what they do. It stops being fine at three points: when somebody presses record, when somebody outside the organization is invited in, and when a training session or presentation is recorded.

At each of those three points the organization currently has no stated rule, so the answer is whatever the individual decided, and it varies. One department announces recordings and asks; another records silently because the platform puts a banner up and that seemed like enough. An external colleague joins a meeting and nothing happens; the same external colleague is added to the chat afterwards and a permanent identity is created in the tenant with no sponsor, no purpose and no expiry.

This document sets one rule for each, and puts the everyday version of it in Appendix A so people can find it without reading the rest.

2. Recording, and the consent rule

2.1 The legal floor, and why the organization does not sit on it

Many US jurisdictions are one-party-consent for the recording of conversations: it is generally lawful to record a conversation you are a party to without the other participants' agreement. Others require every party's consent, so check the law where you and your participants are. Where one-party consent applies, that is the legal floor and it is a low one.

> **The organization's standard is higher than the law requires — deliberately.**
> THE RULE: meetings are recorded openly or not at all. The organiser says at the start that the meeting is being recorded, says why and where it will be kept, and gives people a moment to respond. If somebody objects, the default is not to record.
> The reason to go beyond the legal minimum is not caution, it is that the legal minimum answers the wrong question. "Were we allowed to?" is a question about liability. The question that actually matters in any workplace is whether a colleague or a client can speak candidly in a meeting without discovering afterwards that they were on the record. A community in which people are unsure gets quieter meetings and worse decisions.
> The platform's own recording banner is a notification, not a consent. It appears after the fact, people have learned not to see it, and somebody joining late never sees it at all. The announcement is made by a person.
> RATIFICATION: this is a recommendation from IT. It should be ratified by executive leadership with a view from counsel before it is published as an organization standard, because it touches employment and privacy questions that are not IT's to settle. Owner: Head of IT to table it. Until it is ratified, IT applies it as guidance and says so.

2.2 The rules that follow from it

- The ORGANISER decides whether a meeting is recorded. Not an attendee, and not whoever happens to have the button.
- Recording is restricted to organisers and co-organisers as a tenant setting (§10 of M365-21 applies to changing it). Leaving it open to every attendee means the decision in §2.1 is not actually anybody's.
- Announce it aloud at the start. Say what the recording is for and where it will be kept. If people join late, say it again.
- If somebody objects, do not record — or, where the recording genuinely must happen, offer them a way to take part without appearing, and say so before they have to ask.
- Do not record a meeting covertly, using a separate device, a phone on the desk, or a third-party tool, whatever the law permits. This is the line that a one-party-consent argument is most often used to cross, and the organization's answer is no.
- Do not record one-to-one conversations about a person — a performance discussion, a welfare conversation, a disciplinary meeting — without that person's explicit agreement and, where it is an employment matter, without HR involved from the start (ACC-15 §6).
- A recording made in the course of an investigation is evidence, and it is governed by GOV-03 and M365-16 §8, not by this section.

3. Where recordings and transcripts actually land

Almost nobody knows this, and it decides whether a recording survives the person who made it.

Kind of meeting	Recording and transcript go to	Which means
A normal meeting (calendar invitation, ad hoc call)	The ORGANISER'S OneDrive, in a Recordings folder.	It is a personal file belonging to one member of staff. It is inside M365-12's boundary rule, and if that person leaves it is subject to exactly the problem M365-16 §5 describes.
A channel meeting (started from a channel in a Team)	The Team's SharePoint site, in that channel's folder.	It belongs to the Team. It survives any individual's departure, it inherits the site's classification and retention, and the right people can already reach it.
A meeting in a private or shared channel	That channel's own separate site collection.	Governed and searched separately from the parent Team (M365-07 §5.1). Easy to overlook in a review or an eDiscovery scope.

> **The consequence, stated plainly**
>
> A recording of a meeting that matters to the organization, made by a member of staff who later leaves, sits in an individual's OneDrive. The organization may believe its retention policy holds that content. It may not: an unlicensed OneDrive is auto-archived on its 93rd unlicensed day, and after twelve months of unpaid archive the data may be deleted regardless of retention settings, retention policies, eDiscovery and all holds (M365-16 §5).
>
> THEREFORE: if a meeting recording matters to the organization, hold the meeting as a CHANNEL MEETING in the relevant Team, or move the recording into the departmental site afterwards. The move is the retention. That is a one-line habit that removes a whole class of loss.
>
> This is the same rule as M365-12, arriving from a direction people do not expect it from.

3.1 Expiry

- Meeting recordings are subject to an automatic expiry setting that deletes them after a default period. It is a tenant configuration.
- Tier 3 reports what the organization's current setting is to Tier 4 within 30 days of approval. A default nobody has looked at is a retention decision made by Microsoft on the organization's behalf, and it should at least be a decision the organization has made knowingly (M365-21).
- Auto-expiry deletes to the owner's recycle bin and does not override a retention policy or a legal hold. It does override an assumption, which is what people actually rely on.

4. Transcripts, Copilot notes and AI note-takers

- A transcript is stored with the recording and follows the same rules as §3. Transcription can also be run without recording, and where it is, the §2 announcement still applies — a transcript is a verbatim record of what people said, which is the thing they were worried about.

- Copilot meeting recaps, AI-generated notes and suggested actions are retainable content. They are organization records in exactly the way a set of minutes is, they are discoverable, and they belong under an explicit policy rather than a default (M365-18, M365-16 §6).
- Machine transcription is frequently wrong, and confidently so. A transcript is a finding aid, not the record. Where what was said matters, the audio is the record and the transcript is a way of getting to the right minute of it.

> **AI note-takers joining from outside the tenant**
>
> A growing number of external meeting assistants join as a participant, record the meeting, transcribe it and send the notes to whoever invited them. When one joins an organization meeting, an unmanaged third-party service is receiving organization conversation — including anything a client or a colleague said in it — under terms nobody at the organization has read.
>
> THE RULE: a third-party note-taker or recording bot may not join an organization meeting without prior approval. This is external sharing of organization content and it is assessed as such (M365-14, M365-15, and M365-18 for the AI question).
>
> FOR ORGANISERS: the lobby is the control. If a participant appears whose name you do not recognise — anything reading as “Notetaker”, “AI Assistant”, “Recorder” or an unfamiliar product name — do not admit it, or remove it and ask the person who brought it. You are allowed to; it is your meeting, and it is a reasonable thing to ask.
>
> The same applies in reverse: do not bring your own note-taker into somebody else’s meeting without asking them first.

5. Who gets into your meeting — lobby, bypass and anonymous join

Lobby setting	Who walks straight in	Assessment
People in my organisation	Everyone with an organization account. Everyone else waits.	The right default for an internal meeting with sensitive content.
People in my organisation and guests (RECOMMENDED DEFAULT)	The above, plus tenant guests who signed in.	RECOMMENDED. Everyone who is in the lobby is then somebody you actually have to look at and admit.
People I invite	Only named invitees; everyone else waits, including forwarded attendees.	Right for anything confidential or contentious. Costs the organiser a minute of admitting people.
Everyone	Anybody with the link, including anonymous joiners.	Appropriate for an open event and wrong for anything else. It is also how meeting-bombing happens.

- Anonymous joiners cannot be identified afterwards. They are in the attendance report as a name they typed, which they chose. If who was present matters, do not let anonymous joiners bypass the lobby.
- Dial-in participants are anonymous by default. A meeting with a dial-in number is a meeting anyone with the number and the conference ID can attempt to join.

- Anonymous users may not start a meeting. Otherwise a link circulated a year ago becomes an open room in the organization's tenant that nobody is watching.
- The organiser can remove a participant and can lock a meeting once everyone has arrived. Both are one click, both are underused, and Tier 1 should tell people about them when the question comes up.
- For anything genuinely sensitive: set the lobby to "people I invite", do not forward the invitation, and check the participant list before the discussion starts rather than after it.

6. A meeting guest is not a tenant guest

This is the most consequential distinction in the document because the two acts feel identical to the person performing them.

What you do	What it creates	What it requires
Invite an external person to a meeting	Nothing durable. They join as a participant. There is no account, no directory entry, and when the meeting ends there is nothing left behind.	Nothing. No ticket, no approval, no sponsor. Invite freely — this is what the platform is for.
Add an external person to the meeting CHAT that persists afterwards	A tenant guest — a real identity in your tenant, with a sign-in and an MFA registration.	ACC-10: a named sponsor, a stated purpose, an expiry, and a record.
Add an external person to a Team, a channel or a site	The same tenant guest, plus access to whatever that Team or site holds.	ACC-10 for the identity, M365-14 for what they can reach. Both.
Share a file or a folder with an external person	Depending on the link type, either nothing or a guest identity.	M365-14 §5, decided by the classification of what is being shared.

> **A common case, and why nobody did anything wrong**
>
> A member of staff invites an external colleague into the tenant. The invitation is accepted, the external user completes MFA registration, and a permanent identity now exists — with no sponsor recorded, no stated purpose and no expiry date.
>
> Every individual step in that sequence is reasonable. The member of staff is collaborating with somebody, which is their job. The gap is that the platform makes creating a durable identity feel exactly like adding somebody to a conversation, and nothing in between says "this one is different".
>
> So the rule is not "be careful". It is a bright line: MEETINGS ARE FREE, ANYTHING THAT PERSISTS IS SPONSORED. If you find yourself wanting an external colleague in the chat, in the Team or in the files after the meeting, that is the moment to raise a ticket — and the answer is very often yes, on the same day (ACC-10 §8).

7. Recording a session

Recordings of training sessions and presentations raise a question this document is not competent to answer and should not try to.

- A recording in which participants are identifiable is a record about those people. What follows from that — whether sessions are recorded at all, whether participants may opt out, whether attendance at a recorded session can be required, how long recordings are kept — is POLICY and belongs to senior leadership, with HR. IT will not write it, and a technical department setting privacy policy by default is how organizations end up with a policy nobody agreed to. What IT does state, because it is technical and because getting it wrong is expensive:

1. A session recording lives in the team's Team or site, never in the presenter's OneDrive. A presenter changing role or leaving takes a personal OneDrive with them (§3, M365-16 §5), and months of recordings goes with it.
2. A session recording is not shared, linked or posted anywhere reachable by people outside the intended audience. The people in the recording did not consent to a wider audience by attending a session.
3. The presenter tells the room before recording begins, at the first session and again whenever it resumes, and offers a way to take part without appearing on camera. This is §2 applied to a room where the participants cannot easily object.
4. Requests to release a session recording to anybody outside the intended audience — a relative, an outside employer, an investigator, another department — go to the department that owns those records. Where a formal process is involved they go through M365-16 §8. IT does not release a session recording on request, however reasonable the request sounds.
5. Where a recording is required as an accommodation, that is arranged through the office responsible for accessibility, and the technical delivery is what IT provides.

> **Open — owner: senior leadership, with HR and the Head of IT**
>
> The organization has no published policy on session recording that IT is aware of. Absent one, individual presenters are deciding it session by session, which is inconsistent for participants and offers no protection to presenters either.
>
> ACTION: senior leadership to state the policy position. IT holds the technical rules above in the meantime and will align this section to whatever is decided.

8. Live events, town halls and webinars

- Use one when the audience is large and the communication is mostly one-way — an all-organization briefing, a customer webinar, a public talk. A 300-person Teams meeting where everybody has a microphone is not a briefing, it is a hazard.
- Every event has a named producer who is not the presenter. The producer manages the lobby, the Q and A, the recording and the moment when something goes wrong, and the presenter cannot do that while presenting.
- Rehearse in the actual event, with the actual presenters, on the actual devices. Almost every failure at an event of this kind is a device or a permission that was never tested.
- Registration collects personal data, which makes the registration list a record with a classification and a retention (M365-15, M365-16). Decide before the event who holds it and for how long, not afterwards.

- If external attendees need to submit anything, note the platform constraint recorded in M365-17 §4: Microsoft Forms will not accept file uploads from external users, because uploads land in tenant storage. Design around it rather than discovering it on the day (M365-17).
- Whether an event recording is published afterwards is a communications decision, not a technical one. Where it goes to a whole population, M365-06 applies.

9. Tier 1 troubleshooting — “I cannot hear / cannot join / cannot share”

Worked in order. Roughly four in five of these are resolved before the second column, and the ordering is by how often each cause actually turns out to be the answer rather than by how technical it sounds.

Symptom	Work through, in this order	Then	Escalate when
“Nobody can hear me”	1. Are you muted — in Teams, on the headset, and on the physical device? Three separate mutes, and they are the answer most of the time. 2. Is the right microphone selected in Device settings? 3. Unplug and replug the headset; reselect the device. 4. Leave and rejoin the meeting.	Windows sound settings — input device and app permissions for microphone access. Then restart Teams.	It fails in every meeting and on a second headset. Tier 2, with the device name and model.
“I cannot hear anyone”	1. Speaker selection in Device settings, and the volume on the device itself. 2. Is the meeting audio actually connected — some join paths connect without audio? 3. Rejoin.	Windows output device; the headset’s own pairing if Bluetooth. Bluetooth headsets that are also connected to a phone are a common and very confusing cause.	Persistent across devices. Tier 2.
“I cannot join”	1. Are you signed in as your organization account, or has Teams picked up a personal account? This is the single most common cause. 2. Is the link the current one — forwarded invitations for recurring meetings go stale. 3. Are you in the lobby waiting to be admitted (§5)?	Sign out fully, sign back in. Try the web client to establish whether it is the desktop app or the account.	Sign-in fails or loops. That is an identity matter — ACC-03 and ACC-05, not a Teams fault.
“I cannot share my screen”	1. On macOS, screen-recording permission for Teams in system privacy settings — it must be granted once and Teams must then be restarted. 2. Is somebody else already sharing? 3. Are you an attendee in a meeting where sharing is restricted to presenters?	Restart Teams. On Windows, check that the display driver is current.	It fails after the permission is granted and Teams restarted. Tier 2.
“The meeting is not in my calendar”	1. Check the correct calendar — a delegate or shared calendar is often the one being looked at. 2. Was the invitation sent to a distribution list you are not actually in (M365-04 §6)? 3. Search the mailbox for the subject.	Have the organiser resend. Check for a rule filing the invitation.	A pattern across several people. That is a group membership question, not a meeting one.

Symptom	Work through, in this order	Then	Escalate when
“I cannot record”	1. Are you the organiser or a co-organiser (§2.2)? 2. Is this a channel meeting where the setting differs? 3. Is the meeting already being recorded by somebody else?	Confirm the licence includes it (M365-20).	The organiser cannot record their own meeting. Tier 2.
“Somebody unexpected is in my meeting”	Remove them, then lock the meeting. Both are one click and the organiser can do them (§5).	If the meeting was open to anonymous joiners, change the lobby setting for future occurrences.	It was not accidental, or something sensitive was disclosed. GOV-03, immediately.

Whatever the outcome, record the CAUSE in the ticket and not only the resolution. “Resolved” teaches the next person nothing; “muted on the headset, not in Teams” is the third column of this table for somebody in six months (GOV-02).

10. Service levels

Activity	Commitment (per GOV-06)
Audio, video or join problem during a meeting in progress	Tier 1, immediately, from §9. This is front-door work and it is not queued.
Meeting room or event AV emergency	P1 to Tier 2 (DEV-18). A meeting in progress is not a P3.
“Where did my recording go?”	Answered at Tier 1 from §3, in the conversation.
Recovering a recording deleted or expired	P3 — 2 coverage days, and honestly assessed. Where auto-expiry has removed it, say so promptly rather than searching hopefully.
Approval for a third-party note-taker (§4)	P3 — Tier 4 assessment within 5 coverage days.
Live event or town hall support	Booked at least 10 coverage days ahead, with a rehearsal. Requests inside that window are supported on a best-effort basis and told so.
A meeting intrusion or a disclosure	P1 to GOV-03. Not a Teams ticket.

11. Records

Record	Held in	Retention
Meeting recordings and transcripts	Organiser’s OneDrive, or the Team’s site (§3)	Per the site’s policy (M365-16 §3). Organization recordings belong in a site, not a OneDrive.
Copilot recaps and AI-generated notes	With the meeting	M365-18, under M365-16 §6
Attendance reports	Organiser’s mailbox	As mail (M365-02)

Record	Held in	Retention
Third-party note-taker approvals	IT governance record	3 years
Session recordings	The team's Team or site	Per senior leadership's policy when stated; site policy in the meantime
Event registration lists	The owning department	Per M365-15 classification
Meeting intrusions or disclosures	Security record (GOV-03)	7 years

12. Related documents

ID	Title	Relationship
M365-07	Teams Provisioning, Naming & Lifecycle	The Teams these meetings happen in, and the channel meeting that fixes §3.
M365-12	OneDrive Appropriate Use & Institutional Data Boundary	§3 — a recording in a personal OneDrive is inside the boundary rule.
M365-16	Retention, Legal Hold & eDiscovery	§5 is why §3 matters; §6 covers transcripts and Copilot artefacts; §8 is the only route to release a recording.
M365-18	Generative AI & Copilot Use in M365	Copilot notes, and the assessment of external AI note-takers.
ACC-10	Guest & Sponsored External Account Standard	§6 — the sponsor, purpose and expiry a tenant guest needs.
M365-14	External Sharing & Guest Access Governance	§6 — what an external participant can reach.
M365-15	Data Classification & Handling	Classification of recordings and registration lists.
ACC-15	Acceptable Use & Credential-Sharing Standard	§2.2 — recording conversations about a person, and the monitoring position.
M365-06	Mass Communication & Broadcast Email Approval	Publishing an event recording to a population.
M365-17	Microsoft Forms & Bookings Standard	Event registration, and the external upload constraint.
DEV-18	Conference & Meeting Room AV Standard	Room hardware behind §9 and §8.
GOV-03	Security Incident Response	Intrusions and disclosures.
GOV-02	Service Desk Intake & Ticket Quality	§9 — recording the cause, not only the resolution.
GOV-06	Service Commitments, Priority & Escalation	Supplies §10.

Appendix A — For end users: meetings, recordings and visitors

Source text for the knowledge base. Format per GOV-05. Written to be published as it stands.

If you are going to record, say so

Tell people at the start of the meeting that you are recording, say what it is for, and give them a moment to say something if they would rather you did not. If somebody objects, do not record — or find another way for them to take part. Teams puts a banner up, but people have stopped noticing banners and anyone who joins late never sees it. The announcement that counts is the one you make out loud.

Please do not record a conversation about somebody without their agreement, and please do not record with a phone or another app instead. The rule is not about what is legal; it is about whether your colleagues can speak freely in a meeting, which they cannot if they are unsure.

Where your recordings go — this one surprises people

If you record a normal meeting, the recording is saved in YOUR OneDrive. It belongs to you personally, which is fine for a catch-up and a real problem for anything the organization needs to keep — because when somebody leaves, their OneDrive goes with them.

If you record a meeting that you started from a channel in a Team, the recording is saved in that Team instead. It belongs to the Team, everybody in it can find it, and it is still there in three years.

So: if the recording matters, hold the meeting in the Team, or move the recording into the department's site afterwards. It takes a moment and it is the difference between having it later and not.

Recordings do not last forever

Meeting recordings are set to delete themselves automatically after a while. If you need one for longer than that, move it somewhere it belongs — a Team or a departmental site — rather than assuming it will still be in your OneDrive when you go looking.

Inviting somebody from outside the organization

Inviting an external person to a MEETING needs nothing from us. Send them the link and they can join. Please do that freely — it is what the platform is for.

Adding an external person to a TEAM, a chat that carries on afterwards, or a site is a different thing, even though it feels the same. It creates a real account for them inside the organization's systems, which is something that then exists, has to be looked after, and should have an end date. Just raise a ticket — we will usually say yes the same day, and then it is recorded and somebody knows about it.

Note-takers and AI assistants

If somebody you do not recognise appears in your meeting — especially anything called a notetaker, an assistant or a recorder — you can remove them, and you should. Those are usually third-party services that record and transcribe the meeting and send it somewhere outside the organization. It is your meeting;

removing an uninvited participant and asking about it afterwards is entirely reasonable.

And if you are thinking of bringing one of your own into a meeting, please ask us first, and ask the other participants.

Keeping unwanted people out

For an ordinary meeting the default settings are fine. For anything sensitive, change the lobby setting to “people I invite”, do not let people forward the invitation, and glance at the participant list before you start rather than after. You can also lock the meeting once everyone has arrived, and you can remove somebody — both are one click.

If something goes wrong in the meeting

Nine times out of ten it is one of three things: you are muted somewhere you did not realise (there are usually three separate mutes — Teams, the headset, and the device), Teams has picked the wrong microphone or speaker, or you are signed in as a personal account instead of your organization one. Try those first, then call us on the service desk — if you are in a meeting right now, say so and we will treat it as such.

Appendix B — Organiser’s card for a meeting with people outside the organization

A minute before you send the invitation. Publishable alongside Appendix A.

✓	Before you send it	Why
☐	Decided whether this meeting will be recorded, and will say so at the start	§2 — the announcement is made by a person, not by the banner
☐	Set the lobby appropriately — “people I invite” for anything sensitive	§5 — forwarded invitations are how strangers arrive
☐	Decided whether anonymous or dial-in joining is allowed	§5 — anonymous participants cannot be identified afterwards
☐	Checked whether anything will be screen-shared that the external party should not see	Classification, M365-15
☐	If files need sharing: shared them properly rather than by attachment	M365-14 §5
☐	Clear that inviting to the meeting creates nothing — but adding to the chat, Team or site does	§6, ACC-10. Raise a ticket for that, before rather than after
☐	Watching for an unfamiliar note-taker or recording bot in the participant list	§4 — remove it and ask
☐	If the recording will matter later: holding it as a channel meeting in the Team	§3 — otherwise it lands in your personal OneDrive

Part of the Known Good SOP Catalog by Kevin Zelman, written for small IT shops, contractors and consultants, career-changers and help desk technicians. Adapt the names, tiers and times to your own shop: the times here are cushion, not a promise.